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UNSPOKEN COSTS



Isolation, incarceration, and the prison telecommunications industry

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Beyond Baklava

A food-backed solution for refugee empowerment

BY **RUQAIYAH DAMRAH**

AS STUDENTS SETTLED into the new school year and an autumn breeze rustled through New Haven, mid-September brought an orange dove, mid-flight with a fork and knife in its beak, to 25 Temple Street. Sunlight pooling onto its tangerine bar stools and white-washed brick walls, Havenly Treats—a new Middle Eastern restaurant—was open for business.

The building itself is calm, if not austere. Arabic and Spanish conversations in the kitchen mix with Iraqi music. The aroma of Arab coffee and falafel lingers in the air. For many of its guests and employees, Havenly feels like home.

"We are a mezze bar on a mission," reads a chalkboard hanging on the wall next to the front counter. The other end of the restaurant offers clarification: above a black-and-white painting of a woman mixing ingredients in a bowl are the words "we build economic and political power with refugee women" in English, Spanish, and Arabic. The space is home to an unlikely bunch of superheroes: some sip Iraqi cardamom tea, others blast "Despacito" from behind the counter, and many of them have chosen to don a hijab in place of the traditional cape.

To passersby, Havenly Treats may seem like a quick lunch stop to grab some hummus or stuffed grape leaves. But the restaurant's real stories lie beyond its culinary offerings. From a small, humble partnership between a student and a chef, the restaurant has grown into an enterprising community partnership of refugee women who prepare and sell traditional Arab dishes.

Built on an understanding that everyone brings something to the table and can learn from one another, the restaurant is a testament to the power of community-building. It's the intertwining of so many people and stories—bridging Yale and New Haven, students and refugees, cuisine and education—that makes Havenly Treats unique.

Baklava • بقلاوة

NIEDA AL-ABBAS, Havenly's Head Chef, had long dreamt of opening a restaurant. Now, she is in the kitchen, rolling out sheets of phyllo dough, while directing the other women as they prepare *tabbouleh* and *tzatziki* salad.

al-Abbas, a refugee from Iraq, speaks Arabic to the Sudanese women in the kitchen, and communicates with brief English phrases and gestures with her Latin American co-workers.

Though the women in the kitchen are strangers to one another's languages, they work with each other to serve beautiful, fragrant food—from *mujaddarah*, a hearty rice and

lentil dish, to mezze plates and after-dinner snacks.

Mornings in the kitchen begin with al-Abbas lighting fragrant incense and listening to melodious Quran recitations. "There's a common saying in Iraq," she explained in an interview with *The Politic*. "*Aleafiya darajat*"—blessings and success come step by step. "We climb one step at a time. I believe I can make what I dream come true. I love life…. I love the world."

al-Abbas's daily optimism infuses the kitchen with warmth. She encourages the team to start the day with a positive mindset, and credits her own morning routine with helping her channel gratitude into her work daily.

The space is home to an unlikely bunch of superheroes: some sip Iraqi cardamom tea, others blast "Despacito" from behind the counter, and many of them have chosen to don a hijab in place of the traditional cape.

Fifteen years ago, al-Abbas and her family were lighting incense and listening to the Quran oceans away, back home in Baghdad. But when the U.S. military's occupation in their hometown during the Iraq War tore apart her hometown, she, her husband, and their six children fled to Syria, where they lived for seven years, and then onto Turkey for another four years—years filled with fear, uncertainty, and instability. In 2014, she and her family were finally able to claim refugee status in America.

"The journey was hard," al-Abbas recalled. "I was scared, but I couldn't tell my husband or kids. I had to be the strong one, the hero." Her family settled in New Haven, but it was very difficult for them to adjust to life in America and find employment, especially because al-Abbas and her family didn't speak English.

While al-Abbas was settling in New Haven, Caterina Passoni '18, then a Yale sophomore, was getting involved with the Yale Refugee Project (now the Migration Alliance at Yale). As part of Integrated Refugee and Immigration Service (IRIS)'s Cultural Companions program, which helps refugees acclimate to their new environments, she was paired with al-Abbas's daughter, Maryam. Each weekend, Passoni would visit their home, working with Maryam on her English homework and helping the family adjust to the city.

While the two worked, al-Abbas cooked them Iraqi dishes. "We Arabs are hospitable," al-Abbas explained. "We like to serve a lot of food and sweets. So when [Passoni] came over, I would make platters of foods and sweets for her to try, and she loved the dishes."

As Passoni's Arabic skills progressed, she and al-Abbas were able to communicate more, and the two soon became close friends. "I was a college student missing home, and she made amazing food," Passoni said. "I always say she's like my mom away from my home." Her weekend visits stretched into the next three years.



In 2018, while Passoni was volunteering with IRIS,



"That's when the vision changed from just helping people access jobs in the food business to building something that is actually led by refugee women and their priorities." Passoni explained. "How do we use this space that we're creating together to be one that's really powerful and that amplifies the voices of this community?"

another Yale student, Ben Weiss '19, suggested that they help refugees like al-Abbas sell their food in the residential college Butteries. al-Abbas was immediately on board.

After that, their project "took on a life of its own," Passoni said.

"I was supposed to leave [New Haven] after graduation," Passoni explained, but two years and a $15,000 Tsai CITY grant later, Passoni and al-Abbas are still in New Haven, working on Havenly together.

Kleicha • كليچة

IN HER EARLY CONVERSATIONS with al-Abbas about Havenly, Passoni said that they often exchanged recipe ideas and discussed restaurant service, but rarely did the two speak seriously about Havenly's business model.

Passoni was in for a rude awakening when she connected with Micalea Blei of *The Moth*, a storytelling podcast, who was hired to help with Havenly's marketing strategy. "I went in, told her our story, and she was like, 'This is trash,'" Passoni recalled.

Passoni remembers Blei saying, "When you talk about [al-Abbas] now, you talk about her as a partner, but when you pitch Havenly you don't talk about that as a partnership," Passoni said. "That's when it clicked, and I was like, '[My behavior] is white saviorism at its core.'"

al-Abbas and Passoni envisioned Havenly Treats as a for-profit food business led by al-Abbas that would employ as many women as possible. But she realized that the challenge faced by many refugee women wasn't a lack of workplaces. Rather, the barrier was that they couldn't gain access to workplaces due to language and educational barriers. In response to this problem, Havenly began to identify as a program training refugee women housed in a food-powered solution.

After a team of students conducted research on the factors that affect refugee integration, Havenly was able to debut its core fellowship program for a select number of refugee women who were living in New Haven. The fellowship provided these women with a six-month paid culinary work experience; weekly classes in political advocacy, computer skills, and English as a second language (ESL); and individualized support in searching for and applying to long term employment.

As Havenly began rolling out their fellowship program, the popularity of al-Abbas' baklava increased exponentially at Yale. The small Havenly team scrambled to fill and deliver orders.

In the midst of Havenly's growth during the 2018 and 2019 school years, another partnership was born. Camila Güiza-Chavez '19 was a senior finishing up her Ethnicity, Race and Migration degree. It was March, and she hadn't finalized her plans for after graduation, but she did know she wanted to work in New Haven.

Passoni, who had already heard about Güiza-Chavez's work organizing on behalf of undocumented immigrants, approached her on Cross Campus and asked her to dinner. By the end, Güiza-Chavez was in love with the vision for Havenly that Passoni had laid out and was ready to join her in co-executing and co-directing the fellowship. Three months after graduating, she came back to New Haven full-time and jumped onboard as the fellowship program's Community Outreach Director.

Güiza-Chavez joined around the same time as Malak Nasr '19, a fluent Arabic speaker raised in Cairo. Together, the new team committed to fostering an "equal, meaningful, and productive" partnership at the organization's center.

"That's when the vision changed from just helping people access jobs in the food business to building something that is actually led by refugee women and their priorities." Passoni explained."How do we use this space that we're creating together to be one that's really powerful and that amplifies the voices of this community?"

ISOLATION—due to language, cultural, and physical barriers—is the greatest challenge that refugees face from their first day in the U.S. Adult refugees don't go to school, they often arrive unemployed, and it can be incredibly difficult to find communities of shared language, religion, and background in new, foreign cities. Havenly endeavors to provide the space and resources for refugee women to create those communities themselves.

"We are trying to create multi-racial alliances and cross-racial alliances," explained Passoni. "The community we are creating is being intentionally created across Arab refugees... Sudanse immigrants... now Latinx immigrants."

Havenly's current fellowship cohort is made up of six women, and for the first time, the group includes Spanish-speaking women as well. The women have already grown to be friends, sharing their struggles and stories with each other as they work in the cozy kitchen, finding that many of their experiences are similar.

al-Abbas balances being a friend with the fellows and guiding them as a mentor, building strong relationships within the Havenly fellowship that serve as a support network.

"They see me as a big sister," she said. "Havenly is a family."

According to Passoni, the support that the fellows and staff provide each other "goes both ways. I have received so much support from the women in this program. I will come to Havenly crying and they will make me dinner."

"It was my dream, and it became true," she said with pride. "I told [Passoni], 'This is my key! I can open and close the door with my hand!' It's something really special for us."

Passoni has noticed that most relationship-building moments happen spontaneously and organically. After shifts, the women will practice their digital literacy lessons on the computer, supporting and encouraging each other. On her days off, one of the fellows still takes the time to stop by with her children just to say 'Hi'.

The tight-knit women have also bonded with other members of the community outside of Havenly. When Havenly shared a kitchen in Wooster Square with the bakery Whole German Breads, the employees of the bakery spoke Spanish and listened to Spanish songs in the kitchen. Initially, al-Abbas had reservations about the music selections, but now, Passoni says that al-Abbas always plays "Despacito" on the kitchen speakers.

Since establishing its own physical space downtown, building the Havenly community feels more natural and achievable than it was initially. al-Abbas recalls the feeling of being able to open the door into the restaurant that she dreamed about for so long.

"It was my dream, and it became true," she said with pride. "I told [Passoni], 'This is my key! I can open and close the door with my hand!' It's something really special for us."

The New Haven community rallied around Havenly as it undertook intense cleaning and renovation of the space during summer 2020, redesigning a space which previously served as the seafood restaurant and bar, Mr. Crab.

Over the summer, Havenly partnered with Emerge, a New Haven nonprofit that supports formerly incarcerated people by helping them find jobs in construction, to help with renovations and advise the Havenly team on how to modify the existing space to fit their needs. MakeHaven, a New Haven non-profit center for innovative entrepreneur projects, helped with the painting, signs, and decorative stickers. Miguel Angel Mendoza, an artist who immigrated from Oaxaca, Mexico to New Haven 20 years ago, is planning to paint a mural on Havenly's front window.

"There's something really beautiful and human about seeing something that you create, and for us that's the food we sell."

By mid-September, after months of work, Havenly had its grand opening, and the space felt like home.

"It's such a game changer to be able to have our own place where the women can come and feel some sense of ownership," said Güiza-Chavez. "There's something really beautiful and human about seeing something that you create, and for us that's the food we sell—cooking it here, selling

it here, watching people enjoy it here."

Beyond their culinary offerings, though, Güiza-Chavez imagines Havenly's new physical location as a "whole experience in one place."

"There's a lot of potential...to make the experience an engaging one for customers that come in," she continued, hoping that patrons can "learn about and engage with our mission in different ways."

And although the pandemic has limited what Havenly can do with the space, Passoni, Güiza-Chavez, and al-Abbas have big dreams. They hope to open the building's classrooms and conference rooms to local organizing and advocacy groups. The bookshelf in the corner will be transformed into a learning corner, complete with an armchair and a constant exchange of books as people borrow and share knowledge. On weekends, Havenly will host local performers, artists, and speakers. Graduated fellows, current fellows, staff, and anyone else in the Havenly community will gather at community meetings weekly.

"There's power in the connections and networks created in this space," said Passoni.

Salt • ملح

BEYOND HAVENLY'S PHYSICAL SPACE, al Abbas and Passoni hope their fellowship program will lay the foundation for a more emergent aspect of the restaurant: advocacy efforts. When Güiza-Chavez joined the team, she immediately questioned why Havenly wasn't involved in political organizing. The women in the program have the agency to respond to injustices in the world—she wanted to see Havenly help them realize that and act upon it. And the first step to achieve that goal is building advocacy-based language skills.

The initial ESL curriculum was culinary-based, with the fellows primarily focused on learning words for different objects in the kitchen. However, Güiza-Chavez restructured the curriculum to be more complex and grounded. Now, the fellows are learning English through a discussion of their feelings surrounding social justice issues.

"The fellows learn the words 'Supreme Court' and 'injustice' before they learn 'salt,'" said Passoni. Being equipped with these language tools and learning stories in the advocacy class about community organizers such as Rosa Parks and Ilhan Omar provides the fellows with knowledge about the ways they can influence their own communities.

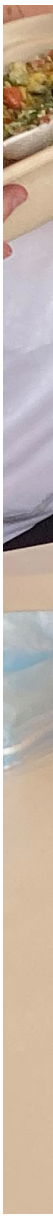
For example, after learning about petition organizing in their advocacy class, the second cohort of women approached Güiza-Chavez and asked if they could start a petition for New Haven public schools to recognize the Islamic holiday of Eid. When the Black Lives Matter movement protested George Floyd's murder this summer, the fellows wrote statements in solidarity that were shared on Havenly's Instagram.

Perhaps the most impactful organizing effort the women have helped organize is the food relief program. When the pandemic first hit in March, Passoni brought it to al-Abbas' and the other fellows' attention that unemployment and financial stress was increasing in New Haven, especially for undocumented immigrants who were excluded from government support. The idea of a food relief program was born, and al-Abbas, who had learned about undocumented immigrants' struggles in the advocacy curriculum, insisted that they donate meals to that community in New Haven.

The program launched in May, with al-Abbas and the other women prepping hundreds of boxes of pea-filled rice, yogurt-cucumber salad, and cheese fatayer to be distributed to the community. The beginning of the program coincided with the Islamic month of Ramadan, which made running the program a difficult task for the women.

Every day, the fellows woke up before sunrise to have a light breakfast in preparation for the day of fasting, then readied themselves for a full day in the kitchen. From 9 a.m. to 5 p.m., al-Abbas and the fellows filled up pots with rice and platters with *fatayer*, trying to ignore their increasing hunger and thirst. The heat was seeping into the kitchen, and the air conditioning hadn't been installed yet. However, as the styrofoam boxes of food stacked up on the counter, the feelings of hunger and exhaustion were replaced by gratitude and fulfillment.

"If you do good for others, it will lift afflictions from the world," said al-Abbas. The food relief program was a huge success, providing 5,000 meals to the New Haven community between May and June, and is still being continued to this day.



"The fellows learn the words 'Supreme Court' and 'injustice' before they learn 'salt,'" said Passoni.

These organizing efforts have made Havenly a transformative force within the New Haven community, one that crosses group identities and recognizes the interconnectivity between different marginalized groups' struggles.

Because the women in Havenly's program face immediate stereotyping upon their entry into the workforce, anti-racism work is especially important to Havenly's mission.

Güiza-Chavez posed the question, "How do we use what we have and really work towards our mission, not just from...



within the walls of 25 Temple Street, but how do we be part of a movement that is working with anti-racist organizers?"

The ultimate goal of the Havenly program is to create an organizing framework in which the women themselves shape the community they're in. Havenly does not aim to simply advocate for refugee women; it seeks to help the women feel that if they see an injustice, they have the agency to change it—because they do.

"How do we use this space that we're creating together to be one that's really powerful and that kind of amplifies the voices of this community?" asked Güiza-Chavez. "That's something I'm excited to keep seeing unfold."

The Soul • الروح

FOR OVER A DECADE, al-Abbas has lived through war, financial uncertainty, and emotional isolation. While she and her family whispered prayers in their home together in Baghdad with hopes for a better life, al-Abbas never would have imagined herself opening a restaurant in a New England college city. Now, she is training a group of fellow refugee women and helping to lead discussions about refugee integration in New Haven.

Havenly's first conversations were centered around ideas for physically transforming their space. Several months and a lot of renovations later, the conversations at Havenly now buzz with ideas about nurturing and transforming communities.

On a normal late afternoon at Havenly, you can find at least a couple of fellows and employees running the front counter while dancing and singing along to Arabic music. Several students are seated along the bar table, doing homework or sharing about local organizing work they're involved in. In the kitchen, al-Abbas and two Sudanese fellows are frying *falafel* and chatting about the similarities between Iraqi and Sudanese cuisine. In a conference room at the back of the restaurant, Passoni and Güiza-Chavez are mapping out ideas for the future of the organization on a whiteboard.

These conversations are at the heart of Havenly, woven into the fabric of the organization. Much as the women developed meaningful relationships with each other, the ever-growing Havenly community continues to touch the lives of everyone who interacts with its mission, whether through a customer admiring their chalkboard art or a newly resettled refugee woman looking for ways to support her family.

The soul of Havenly doesn't lie in its Turkish coffee, its comfort food dishes, or even its signature baklava—it lies in the stories and conversations that have brought the Havenly community together.

False Neutrality

Yale STEM contemplates ethics

BY **KATHERINE CHOU**

JOHN DALLARD '22 had "heard about the deaths and racial incidents with law enforcement, not just this year, but [in] so many previous years, too." This time, however, was different.

As a Computer Science major and the vice president of Yale's National Society of Black Engineers, Dallard has long thought about the consequences of the technology he works with and the impact it will have on others. But this year's COVID-19 pandemic and Black Lives Matter protests against systemic racism have prompted Dallard to reexamine the intersections between ethics and STEM.

"This year, being at home, being stuck in quarantine, there's not much else to focus on except the state of the world," Dallard reflected in an interview with *The Politic*. "It has made me really think, 'How do I want to go about my career and goals with my education? How can I use my Computer Science degree and knowledge to truly effect change?'"

It is a common perception that science and politics exist as dichotomous entities. But 2020 has shown that it is impossible to separate COVID-19 from Black Lives Matter or the election from vaccines. Science informs political actions, and politics influence which scientific developments are prioritized.

As America looks to technology to ameliorate the effects of the pandemic, coronavirus disparities across marginalized groups have underscored the need for racial justice-oriented perspectives in science and tech. Black, Hispanic, and Native American communities have been disproportionately burdened not only with COVID-19 cases and deaths, but also limited access to digital resources. Contact-tracing apps, designed for people who can afford to separate themselves from work and community, have ultimately presented surveillance pitfalls and caused tangential harms to marginalized communities. False positives pose the most harm to lower-income workers who are forced to weigh losing their income or job against their health and safety based on inaccurate warnings. These apps have also raised concerns that they normalize surveillance, which has commonly been applied to marginalized communities, and that sensitive health and social networking data collected could

be reused later for different purposes.

The tensions and interplay between ethics and science are entrenched in Yale's classrooms as well. In light of increasing discourse surrounding the importance of anti-racism training across all sectors, is Yale doing enough to ensure that its future doctors and engineers are equipped to serve all people equally? For some STEM majors, the answer is no.

Like Dallard, Jordan* '21 has also spent a lot of time considering the implications of her work as a Computer Science major and the ameliorative or detrimental impact her work could have. However, she doesn't feel that her major classes adequately address this social impact.

"Yale does not accomplish this sentiment of urgency and high level of responsibility when it comes to innovation and technology use," she wrote in an email to *The Politic*. "In fact, it's kind of hard to remember specific instances warning of negative impact coming from professors, other than as quick side-notes or waved-off comments."

Dallard conveyed the same sentiment: "We won't be in a blackbox, turning in assignments and submitting homework to simply be graded. We will potentially affect a lot of people, and that's nowhere to be found in our courses for a Computer Science degree."

Not having the human implications of their work actively and vigorously discussed in core classes means that STEM students who don't actively choose an ethics elective or distributional requirement might never consider these moral questions during the course of their Yale education.

Karen Tai '21, who majors in Molecular Biophysics and Biochemistry (MB&B), came to Yale convinced that she wanted to go to medical school and that she would focus solely on STEM. She channeled her previous research experience into conducting cancer research at Yale and started volunteering at HAVEN Free Clinic, a student-run clinic that provides access to free health care for the New Haven community. It was those Saturday mornings seeing patients that ignited her interest in understanding the individuals that she works with.

"At the end of the day we're not serving robots," Tai insisted. "We're serving people with complex histories, who have histories of distrust for the medical system."

Many of the people she encounters have had to contend with systemic poverty and medical racism, which complicate their access to care. "Most of my patients don't even have access to insulin shots or even health insurance; the idea of [a] novel treatment for cancer is not even in their mindset. They are more struggling to pay their medical bills or thinking about

"At the end of the day we're not serving robots," Tai insisted. "We're serving people with complex histories, who have histories of distrust for the medical system."

how they're going to get food, how they're going to pay for their housing."

Tai's interactions with HAVEN's clients have led her to question who the $200,000 cancer treatments she helps develop a few buildings over will ultimately serve.

"I love the research I'm doing and I do believe it will potentially help individuals and cancer patients, but it was really hard for me to justify my focus and continuous research on creating these therapies when this potential was not even going to be available to people I considered family and friends," Tai explained.

Volunteering at HAVEN Free Clinic catalyzed Tai's interest in History of Science, Medicine, and Public Health (HSHM) courses and learning more about societal elements of the medical profession.

Yale prides itself on offering students a liberal arts education meant to ensure they are exposed to different disciplines. Yet without actively searching for volunteering opportunities and reflecting on class disparities in healthcare, Tai fears she would never have become invested in taking HSHM courses and gaining a more holistic understanding of medicine.

Other universities have chosen to set more specific graduation requirements. To acknowledge the centrality of ethics in STEM, some of Yale's peer institutions, like Stanford, have integrated ethics requirements into their STEM majors.

Every undergraduate Computer Science major at Stanford must take one of 23 "Technology in Society" (TiS) courses that focus "on ethical issues arising from the interplay of engineering, technology and society," according to Stanford's undergraduate handbook.

As Dev Iyer '24, a Computer Science major at Stanford, told *The Politic*, "I think it's good we have this major requirement because it's important and I honestly probably wouldn't have chosen a TiS class otherwise."

Iyer explained the difficult tradeoff STEM students face between choosing classes that teach them technical skills and those that do not seem as directly relevant to their intended careers. "I know ethics is important, but I'm surrounded by so many exciting technical classes and so little time to take them all. There's a sort of opportunity cost to taking any class."

This "opportunity cost" that STEM students feel when choosing between STEM and humanities classes is exactly what Rob Reich, professor of Political Science at Stanford, believes that universities should help minimize. He helped develop a new Computer Science course, CS182: Ethics, Public Policy, and Technological Change, which enrolled approximately 250 undergraduates when it was first launched in 2018. The next year, the course enrolled "just shy of 300 students," Reich told *The Politic*.

"The goal of the course is to bring about a fundamental shift in how students, whatever their choice of major and whatever their career pathway, think about their role as enablers and shapers of technological change in society," Reich said. "With every new innovation, we want students to ask: What am I enabling others to do?"

But beyond solely being a course for students to consider the ethical and social implications of technological innovation, CS182 was developed "to create an enduring and large undergraduate course that comes to be seen by students as a de facto requirement." Stanford's Computer Science department is working to set the ethical dimensions of computer science as fundamental to the discipline, rather than an extraneous requirement for its students.

Yale certainly has courses, centers, and research groups dedicated to examining the intersection of science and social issues. Dr. Ivano Dal Prete, Director of Undergraduate Studies for the History of Science, Medicine, and Public Health major, told *The Politic* that about 70 percent of HSHM students have taken or are currently taking at least one class in bioethics. HSHM lectures are also becoming increasingly popular among non-majors, drawing "attendance in the hundreds," and he notes that "the majority of those students have certainly been premedical students or STEM." Still, simply creating options may not be enough.

While Yale does have ample opportunity for STEM students to branch out into other disciplines, it is not uncommon for a STEM student to stick almost entirely to courses in their major. Jordan shared that within the Computer Science department, "there are specific courses at Yale one can take to familiarize themselves with the impacts and implications of technology on society, but it's kind of sad to say that most of these courses are not listed as CPSC courses, and they are certainly not widely popular among the [Computer Science] majors." Having only "a rare few [ethics courses] available as electives" is true for many other STEM majors as well.

Anna Rullán Buxó '22, a Chemistry major, explains that taking ethics courses is not simply under-empha-

sized among STEM departments—it is also practically difficult to find scheduling space when there are lab courses and other Chemistry requirements to fulfill using elective credits. As she told *The Politic*, "Even just making it possible for any STEM major to take an ethics course and have it count towards their major—even if it's not required—would help immensely."

Professional Ethics, a course listed under both Yale's Engineering and Applied Sciences and Ethics, Politics, and Economics departments, is one of the few classes that could count towards some STEM majors' requirements. As Professor Mercedes Carreras, who has taught the Professional Ethics course in past years, said in an interview with *The Politic*, "Most of my STEM students have never been exposed to philosophy in their lives. But when they discover philosophers, they love them. Then, for the most part, they want to continue studying those philosophers, and they take more courses on philosophy and government."

Carreras thinks there should be some kind of ethics requirement within STEM majors because "it's important to learn about values and how to make decisions, especially in the sciences."

This would not be easy. Yale's STEM requirements aren't centralized; each department has the freedom to decide what the requirements for its undergraduate program are. An ethics requirement would need to be implemented individually by each department.

Tai has been working to do this for the MB&B major. "We can't pursue the goal of STEM without understanding society and the individuals that we serve," she said.

Since becoming the co-leader of the new student organization, STEM & Health Equity Advocates (SHEA), Tai has worked successfully with the Director of Undergraduate Studies of MB&B to implement a new half-credit requirement for the MB&B major. The proposal that was approved on September 10 of this year mandates one half-credit "in subject matter at the interface of STEM with identity and society" and states that "this new requirement formalizes our [faculty's] view that the intersection of Molecular Biophysics & Biochemistry with human identity and society is critically important to the training of the next generation." Other departments that SHEA has tried to work with, however, have not been so open to adjusting their requirements.

At the same time, major requirements are only about a third of the courses a Yale student needs to take. Dr. Tamar Gendler, professor of philosophy as well as psychology and cognitive science, stressed that incorporating ethics courses into existing major programs may dilute the material.

According to Gendler, teaching ethics specifically within a STEM course can change the perspective and the scope of what is being taught; a science professor has a different background and goal compared to a philosophy professor. STEM students might benefit most from courses in "metaphysics and epistemology, which explore the fundamental nature of reality and our knowledge of it, or a course in ethics or political philosophy, which explores normative structures like goodness and justice. The particular content matters less than the exposure to the methodology."

Gendler's point is reinforced by the fact that the one ethics requirement that does exist across STEM disciplines is externally imposed and has been met with heavy criticism by some students. The American COMPETES Act requires training in ethical conduct in research for anyone working in a lab that receives funding from the National Science Foundation. Any Yale student doing research-for-credit must take a class to satisfy this COMPETES requirement.

Former Chemistry major Nasser Odetallah '20 enrolled in CHEM 490, a class offered in partial fulfilment of this requirement. He found its discussion of ethics sanitized and uncontroversial, as his class evaded harder questions about power structures within the sciences.

In a letter to the Yale Chemistry Department this past April, Odetellah acknowledged that his class did cover topics like "sexual misconduct, plagiarism, the history of scientific journals, publication problems, proper lab mentorship, etc., all of which seemed standard and good to learn about. However, the actual nature of the discussions routinely veered into racist, sexist, classist, and elitist beliefs that were uncomfortable to sit through and discuss."

This semester, Rullán Buxó has noticed that weekly Chemistry department emails show "more effort to include diversity and inclusion workshops, to do education about discrimination in science." Yet she doubts that the department's ethical blindspots "will have drastically changed now after a few months."

Many other questions must also be asked as Yale considers implementing an ethics requirement. What do we mean when we say "ethics?" Who defines ethics and what an ethics class for STEM students should cover? A requirement, as with Stanford, should strive to

create a culture that acknowledges ethics as an integral part of a STEM education, rather than another box to check. How could Yale make an ethics requirement meaningful?

There are universal ethical standards for how to conduct science and implement technology. But such narrow definitions lead to the insufficient introspection that Odetallah noticed in his ethics class. Substantive discussions around ethics must also bring with them difficult conversations about history and social justice that critically challenge established approaches to the sciences.

Without dispelling traditional views about science's objectivity, students cannot partake in meaningful discussion about how the discipline has historically aided systemic racism and

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social injustice. Tai warns that in an age "when genomics is becoming more and more popular and being utilized to create definitions, it's particularly important for researchers in chemistry and biology, who are trying to characterize differences in genomics and how that impacts individuals, to be cognizant of how racial biases can actually be put into the very science that we do."

Even technology itself is not racially neutral, as its algorithms are programmed by researchers with implicit biases of their own. During his internship at Google this past summer, Dallard saw how Google Images could reinforce dangerous myths about racial difference. When one searched "professional hair," the top results were white women with straight hair; when one searched "unprofessional hair," the top results were Black people.

"It's not by virtue of anything intentional; that's just the way the algorithm worked," Dallard emphasized. This is why, he noted, it is important to have "people there in the room who are considering: Even though the algorithm 'works,' *how* does it work and how is it going to affect people?"

Given the pervasive nature of modern technology, Jordan insists that "ensuring it treats its users—and ultimately targets—right should be at the very top of our priority list."

To understand the ethical dilemmas faced in technology, medicine, and any other STEM field, conversations surrounding ethics must take place in diverse environments with racial, gender, and class representation. To achieve this diversity, and to do more than simply promote it on the surface, Tai says, "we need to make people understand why representation is important, and understand that science, while many people think it's objective, because there have been limited perspectives, really is not."

Although Yale is steeped in tradition, the university has evolved significantly over its history. While departments' educational philosophy and requirement structures may not be able to accommodate an ethics requirement for STEM majors yet, there is hope that a cultural shift is on the horizon. Even merely recommending ethics classes to take alongside STEM courses is a step toward ensuring that ethics are embedded in a Yale education.

"As more and more students take such courses, the insights and frameworks that they introduce will become part of the common ground of conversation among Science Hill students," Gendler explained, "creating a self-reinforcing culture of reflective engagement."

Jordan agreed but noted that such change will require real investment from the departments themselves. Yale's "STEM departments [currently don't] invest time into teaching their students about the gory and direct consequences their work can have on real people," she emphasized. "We need to be told some hard truths, and we need to learn from [them], and learn how to make better decisions."

**Name has been changed for anonymity*

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Isolation, incarceration, and the prison telecommunications industry

XEN OSTS



BY **MARIA ANTONIA SENDAS**

Suddenly women are shouting from high up, and balled-up bits of paper are scattered on the sidewalk like fat, chewed up pearls, and I want to open one, because they seem to have dropped from a distant world.

"This is not right," my father says grimly.

I always feel like I'm dreaming when I walk by the ladies' house of detention. It's tall, with columns of dark windows, and it's a prison, yet ladies are calling out from the inside, and I don't understand what they're shouting. If they are locked up and out of reach, how can they drop these wadded papers?

What are they trying to say?

We walk downtown some more, on narrow streets. Finally I ask, "Why do they drop those paper balls?"

My mother sighs. "They write down their names and phone numbers on those slips," she says. "They're shouting for people to call their husbands and children, and give them messages."

"Like what messages?" I'm thrilled. These little white balls are like light from stars that died long ago.

"I love you," my mother says brightly. "What else?"

—From "16 Minetta Lane" by Dylan Landis in "What My Mother and I Don't Talk About," 2019

AT JUST 19 YEARS OLD, Serena Liguori was incarcerated and placed in protective custody.

Protective custody, while purporting to shield incarcerated people from harm, ultimately mirrors the experience of solitary confinement. Liguori remained in her cell for 23 hours a day. During her remaining hour, Liguori showered, made food,

did her laundry, and called her family. With the spread of COVID-19 in prisons across the United States, prisons and jails nationwide have increased their use of solitary confinement and protective custody to mitigate the transmission of COVID-19.

"There isn't enough time to help people behind bars have a humane way of living and have that connection with the outside world," Liguori told *The Politic*.

It's Tuesday, November 3—roughly eight months since the pandemic began. The bold white number on the screen grows from 0 to 169,286 as The Marshall Project's main page loads. The Marshall Project, an online journalism organization dedicated to criminal justice issues, is tracking the spread of COVID-19 in prisons across the United States. Since April, there have been at least 1,363 reported COVID-19-related prisoner deaths in the U.S., with cumulative coronavirus cases among incarcerated people nearly five times higher than that of America's general population. Greater virus transmission rates in prisons are the result of overcrowded and unsanitary correctional facilities and the vulnerability of elderly or sick incarcerated people. Citing these numbers, advocates have called to reduce the number of people held in custody to help protect incarcerated individuals from the coronavirus.

Along with the massive rise in national unemployment, the pandemic has exacerbated many Americans' mental health struggles, causing an overall increase in depression and anxiety. To offset the emotional toll of the pandemic, experts recommend getting outside and utilizing mental health resources and technology to speak with friends and family members. Those disconnected from their traditional support networks have learned that these methods for maintaining and promoting mental, emotional, and physical well-being are not "options," but bare necessities—ones largely denied for the incarcerated.

The mental health impacts of the coronavirus are further exacerbated by barriers to communication for those in prison. For years, the prison telecommunications industry has imposed prohibitive costs on the exchange of phone calls, text messages, or letters with those incarcerated.

Abby Leighton '24 and Naheem Watson '24 are the Project Heads for Free Prison Phone Calls, a group supported by the Yale Undergraduate Prison Project. They have worked with Worth Rises, a national advocacy organization pushing for free prison phone calls in many states.

While jobs for those incarcerated can pay as little as 12 cents per hour, phone calls to the outside world can cost up to one dollar per minute, Leighton and Watson explained in an email interview with *The Politic*. This financial levy blocks communication between the incarcerated individuals—the majority of whom come from low-income backgrounds—and their families, friends, and vital support networks on the outside.

The pandemic's resulting economic downturn has exposed how this disconnect disproportionately affects working-class families. Unemployment levels have reached historic records in the last few months, and while some people are finding new sources of income, many are still in vulnerable and unstable situations.

This is what Free Prison Phone Calls seeks to change. "Prison is already a lonely and isolated place," Leighton and Watson said. "Free phone calls are one step that can relieve the financial and emotional toll that incarceration has on people and their families."

"I think the biggest misconception that people have about prison is that 'the state' pays for everything. No one realizes that it's the friends and families of loved ones that pay."

—Connie Martin, from Hazel Park, Michigan, wrote to *The New York Times*

TWO COMPANIES—Securus and Global Tel Link (GTL)—have the power to dictate the cost of communication for America's 1.5 million plus incarcerated people. Securus serves over 3,400 correctional facilities in the country, while GTL provides services for more than 2,400. The very existence of this duopoly exploits incarcerated people and their families: Due to these giants' influence, there exists no competition to moderate the providers' high prices.

"What we've seen in the past is that the telecom companies that offer phone call services to prisons and jails will charge rates that are much higher than necessary," Prison Policy Initiative (PPI) Communications Strategist Wanda Bertram told *The Politic*.

Together, Securus and GTL have sent one in three families communicating with an incarcerated loved one into debt due to the high communication cost.

The Federal Communications Commission (FCC) has capped the cost of out-of-state phone calls from jails and prisons at 21 cents a minute, according to a PPI report. But when Securus and GTL add hidden fees to the overall cost of calls—which includes costs to open and maintain an account or receive paper bills, among others—they can technically respect the FCC's cap on prison phone rates while creating a new source of revenue on which they are not required to pay commissions to prison facilities. In addition, by buying out non-telephone companies that provide other services like videoconference technology, electronic tablets, and money transfer for commissary accounts, they can offer "bundled contracts" to jails and prisons, which combine phone contracts with other services and allow them to charge higher prices.

These contracts allow providers to "shift profits from one service to another, thereby hiding the real costs of each service from the facility," the PPI reported. "Bundling also 'locks in' contracts for the provider: It makes it more difficult for the facility to change vendors in the future, because the facility must now change their phone, email,

"EVERYTHING ABOUT BEING INCARCERATED IS REALLY EXPENSIVE... THEY FIND EVERY WAY TO PUNISH YOU."



Photo taken at New Hour's farm visit for families impacted by the carceral system

commissary, and banking systems all at the same time."

But the telecom companies are able to keep the prison facilities satisfied by sharing a portion of their revenue with them. Though they manage to keep some costs hidden from both the users and the facilities, as the PPI report outlines, they still kick back part of the revenue to the facility to incentivize prisons and jails to work with them, Bertram explained.

According to Bertram, the PPI is currently advocating in Iowa—where the Utilities Board is considering regulating the costs of phone calls from jails. Similar to Iowa, the California Public Utilities Commission (CPUC) has recently signaled its intention to regulate the capping of prison and jail telephone calls. She explained that the PPI immediately drafted a comment "to make sure that the CPUC understood just how big of an issue this is and urging the CPUC to take big bold action."

"There's a lot of different ways counties and cities can bring down the cost of phone calls and video calls, and we're trying to follow up on all possible happenings," Bertram continued. "[The PPI has] been advocating to the Federal Communications Commission for years, [as the FCC has] the power to regulate the cost that the companies impose on customers and lobbying public utilities for it."

This action can come on at the grassroots level as well. Liguori, after completing her incarceration and surviving solitary confinement, dedicated her life to prison reform and has worked tirelessly to support women whose lives have been torn apart by the carceral system. Currently, Liguori is the Executive Director of New Hour for Women and Children, a Long Island-based nonprofit organization dedicated to women and children impacted by incarceration.

"I think back to my own time being incarcerated, and the enormous burden it was for my younger sister to accept my collect phone calls," Liguori said. "And [the price of phone calls] limits the amount of support you can receive because you feel bad calling someone and spending their money at 15 dollars a call."

Since New Hour accepts collect calls from women, Liguori explained, members of the organization have witnessed the high level of anxiety within prisons and jails during the pandemic.

"One of the things that the sheriff's office did here in Suffolk [County] is they allowed women to have [one] free collect phone call. And that's great, but I'd love to see that happen for all the women everywhere, every day. The levels of depression and anxiety go up when you're incarcerated," Liguori said. "Most of the women incarcerated during COVID-19 weren't even worrying about themselves—they're worrying about their children and loved ones."

Still, the issue of predatory prison communication costs persists. Eager to combat this, two Yale students created Ameelio, a technology start-up that allows users to freely communicate with incarcerated loved ones. Co-founded in 2019 by Uzoma "Zo" Orchingwa YLS '22 and Gabriel Saruhashi '21, the app aims to dismantle the carceral system's financial barriers to communication that separate families, thereby disrupting the entire prison telecommunications industry, which boasts 1.2 billion dollars a year in profits.

According to Orchingwa, Ameelio is the first free prison communications platform in the United States, allowing users to send free letters, photos, postcards, and art to incarcerated loved ones. Through the app, users can write a 9,000 character message and include attachments. The message is converted into a physical letter, which

is sent to the facility through an automated third-party service. Early next year, Ameelio plans to launch a free prison video-calling service, which will "enable families to have real-time video communication with incarcerated loved ones," Orchingwa said.

Throughout the COVID-19 crisis, Ameelio has served over 50,000 families and incarcerated individuals and sent over 100,000 free letters and postcards to facilities. The Robin Hood Foundation, Mozilla Foundation, Fast Forward, CEO of Twitter and Square Jack Dorsey, and former CEO of Google Eric Schmidt are just some of Ameelio's most well-known supporters.

"Ameelio's mission is to fundamentally transform this industry," Orchingwa told *The Politic*. "To use technology to accelerate the creation of a more humane and rehabilitative justice system. We will continue to build free communication tools in order to reconnect incarcerated people with their families and relevant resources to help them successfully reintegrate into society."

A deadly pandemic like we are facing now is even deadlier in prisons all over the world. My best friend is incarcerated in Florida, where we happen to have several cases of the virus. His facility is on restricted movement, lines for the phones and computers are much longer, and calls have been restricted to only 10 minutes.

—Shelby, Ameelio user

WHEN PRISONS suspended in-person visitations due to the COVID-19 pandemic, they also increased the financial barrier to communication for incarcerated populations.

Writer and decarceration activist Sarah Resnick spoke to *The Politic* about her experience as a volunteer for the Parole Preparation Project NY, an organization dedicated to supporting people serving indeterminate sentences and transforming the parole system in the state, during the COVID-19 pandemic.

When the pandemic began, Resnick began working on medical clemency appeals. As part of the Parole Preparation Project's effort to raise commissary funds for people in prison, she began sending people money out of her own pocket through JPay, a correctional money transfer service owned by Securus. With a few extra dollars, Resnick hoped that those inside could afford basic medical necessities in case there was a lockdown.

"Everything about being incarcerated is really expensive. Too expensive…. They find every way to punish you," she told *The Politic*.

As she was sending them money through JPay, inmates could then contact her directly through the platform, which encompasses email service, video visitation, and other features in addition to money transfer. This channel allowed them to air grievances that revealed the tragic realities of the prison telecommunications industry during COVID-19: In their letters and emails, Resnick's incarcerated clients expressed fear about additional dangers of COVID-19 within prisons and having limited access to information about the dangers of the virus because of the expense of communication.

"Approximately 4,800 characters [about 800 words] requires one 'stamp,'" Resnick wrote in an essay for *n+1*. "Longer emails require more stamps. Each attachment requires one stamp. Each thirty-second 'video gram' requires four stamps. Ten stamps cost 3 dollars. One hundred stamps cost 23 dollars."

Resnick explained that because of suspended in-person visitations, the New York State Department of Corrections and Community Supervision (DOCCS) has granted each person one free phone call, two free emails, and five free postage stamps per week. Resnick wrote that the DOCCS would increase the number of calls to two.

Meanwhile, many other local and state governments have done the opposite. According to Leighton and Watson, some states have decided to roll back initiatives from earlier in the pandemic that provided more phone calls to incarcerated individuals. Officials have justified this by claiming that in-person visitations will be resumed soon, even though they are still not safe for many families.

With limited external communication in the best of times, information about health violations taking place during the pandemic inside prisons has reached few in the outside world. Speaking to this, Resnick described her correspondence with inmates as "heartbreaking."

Some emails, Resnick shared, complained about the lack or under-enforcement of health protocols by correctional institutions, which has led to a failure in protecting vulnerable or older people with underlying health conditions. Other emails expressed confusion about transferring people to other prisons, an action that seemed counterproductive in slowing the spread of the virus. Still others contained frustrated words about the DOCCS's censorship of messages, including information about what is going on inside.

"I don't even really know how to describe how terrible it was to read these fearful emails and feel really scared myself out here. I was blown away by the disparity between what I was reading—what people were saying about the circumstances inside—and what our politicians were saying," Resnick told *The Politic*.

PPI's Bertram mirrored her concern. "It makes a lot of sense that there [is a] deep mistrust of official information sources. [Incarcerated people] need information about the virus and they need it from their family and their loved ones," she emphasized.

"At the beginning of the pandemic," Resnick said, "none of us really understood how to mitigate the virus, even for ourselves, as the health guidance was consistently changing. Translate that into a space where you can think of information arriving there [in] a slightly delayed fashion, or always third or fourth hand, so it's never really coming direct from the source and

the way that, you know, those kinds of things can quickly become misinformation, or rumors."

Playing on irony, given what she feels is New York's failure to protect the humanity of its incarcerated population, Resnick quoted Governor of New York Andrew Cuomo's motto throughout the pandemic: "Practice humanity."

My husband and I normally would talk on the phone 4 times a day and send messages 3 to 4 times a day, along with visits every Saturday and Sunday. The pandemic of Covid-19 has drastically changed our lives. For months now we have not been allowed to visit. I started using Ameelio.org to be able to send him extra love and it was great because I could send a picture with each letter. Then came the lockdown/quarantine of the whole prison. We could no longer talk on the phone or send messages. The only communication we had were letters. Inmates were allowed to call home twice a week but the phones in my husband's dorm were broke[n] (so no phone calls for us).

—Tele, Ameelio user

AMEELIO'S ORCHINGWA told *The Politic* that the coronavirus has made an already-terrible situation even worse. Other experts agree.

"We've seen pretty substantial increases in reports of depression, anxiety, and suicide attempts in those who are currently incarcerated," explained Dr. Arielle Baskin-Sommers, Associate Professor of Psychology and Psychiatry at Yale, in an interview with *The Politic*. Baskin-Sommers studies the psychological underpinnings of phenomena associated with criminality, and she is worried about the effects of COVID-19 on this vulnerable population.

"Those who are incarcerated have higher rates of those experiences to begin with," said Baskin-Sommers. "[And now], they have been completely cut off from contact with the outside world or any sense of comfort."

Baskin-Sommers confirmed that many individuals who are incarcerated come from low-income neighborhoods, where COVID-19 has had a disproportionate impact.

"As a result, many individuals who are incarcerated are experiencing great loss and grief because their family members are perishing as a result of the pandemic," Baskin-Sommers said.

Those impacted by the carceral system, particularly those who live below the poverty line, are not afforded the same opportunities to recover from trauma, Liguori added. She told *The Politic* that New Hour, her organization, organized a visit to Cornell Cooperative Farm to give mothers, grandmothers, and children a chance to connect despite the impact of incarceration.

"Being able to offer them a safe space at a farm, fresh air, to pick a pumpkin, is not taken for granted," Liguori said.

According to Baskin-Sommers, the stressors that everyone is experiencing are heightened for those who are incarcerated. Most people who are quarantining at home can reach out to talk to family or therapist, or access online mental health resources if they are feeling stressed or anxious. "Those who are incarcerated," Baskin-Sommers emphasized, "cannot."

"I'm sorry that you have to be deprived out there. In here we laugh cuz now maybe people feel, even just a lil', what it's like to be locked down :-) I do want things for you to get better though. Please keep taking good care of yourself and stay strong mentally in these trying times.'"

—Excerpt of an email from an incarcerated person to Resnick, quoted in her essay

DESPITE THE pandemic causing, as Liguori describes, "a void of information" and an atmosphere of "fear and anxiety" in prisons, there has been remarkable resilience among some of society's most marginalized members.

"Incarcerated people and their loved ones have asked us to directly address mental health issues by providing informational postcards with resources as well as tangible activities such as games, puzzles, and uplifting literature," Orchingwa explained.

For Liguori, what is needed now is continued discussion in the public sphere about the issues facing those incarcerated, particularly as the Black Lives Matter movement has reinvigorated the call for prison and criminal justice reform.

"Right now, we're in this national waking up moment…but very few people are talking about incarcerated lives, an overwhelming majority of whom are Black and Hispanic. And they're not getting any real care," Liguori explained.

Although she has long left protective custody, Liguori is prepared to spend the rest of her life advocating for those silenced within the prison system. She emphasized, "It's almost like it is a voiceless population that nobody hears about."



DOWN WITH THE KING.

CALLS FOR DEMOCRATIC REFORM IN THAILAND

BY **SAI RAYALA**

AT 4:45 A.M., Pavin Chachavalpongpun and his partner stood face to face with a man who had broken into their house in Kyoto, Japan, dressed in all black. His partner immediately jumped out of bed and ran after the intruder, but the culprit was able to escape out the front door. Meanwhile, Chachavalpongpun began to feel a burning sensation on his skin—the intruder had chemically sprayed him before fleeing the building. Although the police arrived soon thereafter and began to investigate, Chachavalpongpun already knew who was behind the attack: the Thai government.

"The moment that I woke up and saw this man for one to two seconds in the dark, I knew it," Chachavalpongpun told *The Politic* about the incident, which occurred on July 8, 2019.

Chachavalpongpun, an associate professor at Kyoto University and a Thai dissident, has long been a vocal critic of Thailand's military-led government and constitutional monarchy—stances that have made him a subject of interest to the Thai government. Authorities issued a warrant for Chachavalpongpun's arrest five years earlier, and he claims to have faced constant harassment from the government and its supporters ever since.

The Thailand government has denied any involvement in the attack, and the Japan police are still investigating the incident. However, Chachavalpongpun's early morning encounter would not be the first time that Thailand was accused of committing state violence across international borders. Over the years, nine critics of the Thai monarchy have disappeared and been presumed dead in Vietnam, Cambodia, and Laos.

"It is widely believed and has been said by activists at protests that those actions were done at the behest of the king," Dr. Tyrell Haberkorn, a professor of Southeast Asian Studies at the University of Wisconsin-Madison, said in an interview with *The Politic*. King Maha Vajiralongkorn took over the throne in 2016 after the death of his father, King Bhumibol. While King Bhumibol was a beloved figure in the public, the current king has not yet been able to achieve the same level of reverence.

In recent months, thousands of protesters have descended upon Thailand's streets, revolting against government attempts to censor its most prominent critics. The protests, although concentrated in Bangkok, have spanned the country and are largely organized by student leaders, who call for democratic reforms to the country's military-led government and an end to the harassment of government critics. The movement has outlined three key demands: Democratic changes to the constitution, ending harassment of government critics, and the dissolution of the current parliament. They are some of the largest mass demonstrations the country has witnessed in decades.

THE FIRST SPARKS OF PROTEST can be traced back to Thailand's 2014 military coup, in which the country's current Prime Minister, Prayuth Chan-o-cha, assumed power after his military forces ousted the democratically-elected government. It was Thailand's 13th coup since 1932 when the country's absolute monarchy came to an end with the Siamese Revolution. Since assuming power, Chan-o-cha has made repeated changes that many say blatantly increase his military power, such as enacting a new constitution.

In 2017, a military-appointed committee wrote a new constitution, following a national referendum the previous year. The new constitution gives the military government authority to issue orders against activity the government sees

"THE MOVEMENT HAS OUTLINED THREE KEY DEMANDS:

DEMOCRATIC CHANGES TO THE CONSTITUTION, ENDING HARASSMENT OF GOVERNMENT CRITICS, AND THE DISSOLUTION OF THE CURRENT PARLIAMENT."

as a threat to national security or the monarchy. It also created an army-appointed upper house with six seats reserved for the military and a proportional voting system to reduce the influence of political parties.

In March of 2019, Thailand held democratic elections for the first time since the 2014 coup. After Chan-o-cha's party won the elections, critics claimed that the process was manipulated in order to keep Chan-o-cha in power.

"The constitution was written in such a way that even though elections were being held, the balance of power and the fact that it was in the hands of the military wasn't going to change," Haberkorn said.

In February of 2020, the Thai Constitutional Court dissolved the progressive Future Forward Party, a leading opposition party in the 2019 elections, claiming that the party violated financial rules. The party had represented the hopes of young Thai voters for a democratic future, and its dissolution served as a catalyst for these past months of dissatisfaction and large-scale student protests.

"The current government has lost a tremendous amount of legitimacy because of the way the election was handled, the many corruption scandals that the military has faced, and [because] the economy is terrible," Haberkorn said. "Even people who might have not cared before are not supporting [the government] because they are being affected directly."

As the COVID-19 pandemic erupted across the globe, the movement waned for a time as Thailand enforced emergency restrictions and guidelines. However, in July, protests flared once again after the unexplained disappearance of Thai pro-democracy dissident Wanchalerm Satsaksit on Thursday, June 4. Satsaksit became the ninth in a long list of dissidents presumed to have been killed by the Thai government in the past two years.

On Wednesday, August 26, demonstrations in Bangkok erupted in full force once more, drawing crowds of over 10,000 people. But protesters returned with a new demand: reforming the royal monarchy.

ALTHOUGH OFFICIALLY A constitutional monarchy, Thailand's government is largely controlled by King Maha Vajiralongkorn. The king must approve every change in governmental power, including the 12 successful coups that have occurred since 1932.

The monarchy's influence also pervades the criminal justice system. Above the judges' panel in every courtroom hangs one picture of the current king and one of his father.

"The judges view their role not as serving the people, but as serving the king," Haberkorn explained.

Another point of contention among the Thai public is the monarchy's assets. Although the king's private assets have historically been kept separate from public funding of the monarchy, when King Vajiralongkorn assumed power in 2016, he activated a clause in the country's constitution that grants him personal control over all funds—including those

from public taxes.

"That's why the protesters are on the streets today," Chachavalpongpun explained. "Because they want immediate reform of the monarchy. Because the monarchy has been too long here now controlling [and] dominating Thai politics. If you want to only tackle the issue with the government, you only do it on the surface without going deep into the root of the crisis—which is the monarchy."

In the past, few people were willing to openly criticize the monarchy. Thailand's lese-majeste laws—among the strictest in the world—make it illegal to offend, defame, or threaten the king or the royal family. Even insulting the monarchy can lead to a prison sentence of up to 15 years.

Chachavalpongpun is familiar with these laws. Two days after the 2014 coup, he found himself on a list of people summoned by the new Thai government for an "attitude adjustment" due to his criticisms of the monarchy. Chachavalpongpun immediately rejected the summons.

"First I thought I did nothing wrong," Chachavalpongpun said. "Being critical, why should I be wrong?"

About a week later, he was on the receiving end of another summon. He decided to ignore the second one as well. Two weeks later, the Thai government issued a warrant for his arrest.

As Chachavalpongpun was in Japan when his arrest warrant was issued, the Thai government revoked his passport, forcing him to apply for refugee status in Japan. Even then, his troubles were not over. He recalled experiencing harassment from the Thai government and Royalists—Thai government supporters—whenever he traveled abroad for the next two years until the recent attack in his home.

"I think what bothered them is basically my position vis-à-vis the monarchy rather than the government," said Chachavalpongpun. "Because at least you do not have laws against those criticizing the government, but you definitely have laws against those criticizing the monarchy."

IN ADDITION TO DEMANDING democratic reforms of their government, Thai student leaders are also calling for a 10-point reform of the monarchy that includes cutting the king's budget, separating his private funds from the crown's assets, and ending the lese-majeste laws.

"Looking at the Twitter hashtags, it's clear that more people than ever are questioning the institution of the monarchy and its role in the polity," said Haberkorn. "And that hasn't happened [before]. That's a new phenomenon."

Netiwit Chotiphatphaisal is a 24-year-old student pushing for reforms in Thailand's education system, which includes advocating against the Thai military's presence in schools. He was one of the many activists in attendance at a recent protest on Saturday, September 19.

"We lived in fear about [protesting] for many years, for hundreds of years maybe, so [it is] very amazing to have that happen," Chotiphatphaisal said in an interview with *The Politic*.

Many of the first protests were student-led, emerging in schools and universities across the country. Chotiphatphaisal believes that students are particularly invested because they have grown up in political unrest and are concerned about their futures. He also stated that students' fewer formal responsibilities allow them to "take a chance and do what their conscience demands of them."

"Many of these people grew up under Prayuth, under the military regime, without real freedom," Chotiphatphaisal said. "I suppose these are really the ones who see themselves inheriting this kind of society."

Chachavalpongpun also believes that social media has emboldened students to openly challenge the monarchy.

"Social media is sort of like a platform for the younger generation to express their political opinion," Chachavalpongpun said. "From cyberspace, it has been transported to the street."

Chachavalpongpun is no stranger to the power of social media—and the threat that it presents to the Thai government. During the COVID-19 pandemic lockdown, when Chachavalpongpun was stuck at home, he started a Facebook page called the Royalist Marketplace.

"I thought to myself, 'Hmm, they have a real marketplace,'" Chachavalpongpun said. "Why can't I set up a kind of marketplace where people come and trade ideas and opinions, especially about the monarchy?"

Within four months, the page garnered over one million followers with people from all over Thailand and abroad accessing the page. That's when the government took notice.

The Thai government ordered Facebook to shut down the Royalist Marketplace, which Facebook refused to do. The government then ordered Facebook to block access to the page in Thailand and threatened to charge the company under the Computer Crimes Act if it did not comply.

"THAT'S WHY THE PROTESTERS ARE ON THE STREETS TODAY... BECAUSE THEY WANT IMMEDIATE REFORM OF THE MONARCHY."

Chachavalpongpun said that his page was blocked in Thailand on Monday, August 24.

Chachavalpongpun immediately decided to set up another Facebook group. That page now has over 2.1 million members and is still accessible in Thailand.

"[The government] knows that this is a cat and mouse thing," Chachavalpongpun said. "You close it down. I opened it… I can open it every time it is closed down."

Not everyone, however, agrees with the 10-point demands for reforming the monarchy that the protesters have detailed—or is willing to state their support publicly.

"There are a lot of people that want to see changes, but do not want to get their hands dirty," Chachavalpongpun said.

A Thai graduate student studying in the U.S., who wished to remain anonymous, noted that the protests are particularly contentious because of the generational shift the movement represents.

"Thailand is super hierarchical," the student explained in an interview with *The Politic*. Young people's place at the forefront of this movement "upsets a lot of the traditional norms that people, especially in the older generation, are just not comfortable with."

The older generation grew up with the former King Bhumibol who many felt profound love and respect for, as Haberkorn explained. On the other hand, the current king is a much more controversial figure and is not as well-liked by the public, especially the youth.

The student explained how, even within families, members are conflicted over the issue. In the student's own family, relatives have accused the student protesters of being barbaric and attacking the police.

"I saw the footage," the student said. "The students did not attack the police.… But they buy into it. So there is a real tension between the young and the old, and I don't think it is going away anytime soon."

Even those that have taken the radical step of calling for reforms to the monarchy are not calling for a complete dissolution of the monarchical system.

"They don't want to be killed," said Haberkorn. "That's why, last week, when people started calling for a republic, it was truly remarkable."

On Sunday, November 8, Thailand riot police fired water cannons at crowds of protesters who gathered in Bangkok's Grand Palace to deliver letters to the king calling for reform. The incident marks the second time water cannons have been used against protesters in the last few months.

Even though King Vajiralongkorn has not invoked the lese-majeste laws against any of the protesters yet, the government is still arresting student protest leaders. The threat of violence still looms.

DESPITE THE PROTESTERS' demands for democratic reform, the future and stability of Thailand remain unclear. Many wonder whether it is possible for constitutional reform to take place or if Thailand will once again face a coup and return to a military dictatorship.

According to Haberkorn, the trajectory depends on a multitude of factors, including what the army, current Prime Minister and cabinet, and king all decide to do. However, she believes that the smart thing to do is to agree to the demands for reform.

"The calls for reform are growing. And they're not going to go away," said Haberkorn. "Even if the main 20 leaders were arrested and imprisoned right now, another 20 people would rise to take their place. That's the stage where things are."

The Thai graduate student explained how neither side looks like it is going to concede. But he believes the window for discussion and compromise is still open and that it is still possible to reach an agreement.

"The country is not okay," the student said. "You can't just keep faking democracy. You can't keep abusing human rights—making people disappear."

Chachavalpongpun continues to be a fierce critic of the government and the monarchy, despite—and perhaps "even more so" because—they have compromised his safety and exiled him from his home country.

"Would you want to compromise just because you feel fear? Then you would have to stop everything.…" Chachavalpongpun said. "I am a Thai person. I just wish [for] my country to be more democratic. I hope that whatever I say and whatever I do—that would help towards, even in a tiny way, the democratization process in my own country. So that's why I would never stop."

"…IT'S CLEAR THAT MORE PEOPLE THAN EVER ARE QUESTIONING THE INSTITUTION OF THE MONARCHY AND ITS ROLE IN THE POLITY."

Twin Pandemics

An autopsy of the current moment

BY **ISIUWA OMOIGUI**

"ONCE AGAIN I REALIZED that, from inside these walls, life or death don't count or matter, not even in large scale matters like this," the woman wrote from prison in her letter to Mourning Our Losses (MOL).

Endless columns of names descended on the television screen. Each unintelligible black scribble stretched out like a hand towards the ineffable things words can't say. For how can a name capture a life? Behind the barbed wire and the thick walls and the cold steel bars, the woman sat watching, scanning for names of people who died of the coronavirus while incarcerated.

She found none. This did not surprise her. Incarcerated people, rendered invisible and leprous by the state in life, remained that way even in death. Crushed by mainstream media's inability to even acknowledge the incarcerated dead and the government's refusal to do so, she cried and let the darkness of her prison cell take over.

As I write this, flat lines appear on monitors in hospital rooms. Somewhere and everywhere, a doctor is calling the time of death while families grieve. Rather than grappling with the nearly 250,000 deaths in America and mobilizing to prevent further harm,

this country has embraced partisan rhetoric about common-sense public health measures, opting to sacrifice human lives at the altar of the economy.

Centuries before America recorded its first coronavirus death, the nation had a long tradition of valuing some lives more than others. We were never in this together because we don't see and acknowledge all people. Our empathy is selective and exclusionary.

But the demographics of the death toll and the collective apathy towards those demographics tell an even more frightening story about who America is, whose lives we value, and the ever-widening gulf between our history and the stories we tell ourselves. American institutions' systematic disregard for Black and brown lives not only informs their policies, but has made the American public numb to the suffering and humanity of the most vulnerable among us.

At a September 21st rally, President Trump proudly proclaimed that the coronavirus affects "virtually nobody." In the eyes of those in power, poor, sick, Black, and brown people are nobodies. Racism and capitalism are in the muscle memory of American society and institutions, and the racial disparity of the coronavirus deaths is evidence of the continual assault on Black and brown lives—the dismissal of our humanity. This could not be more evident in the current moment. The price of admission to this presidency was racism: Racist birther conspiracies and the attack on the nation's first Black and South Asian Vice-President elect were its bookends. 62.98 million people sanctioned the dehumanization of people of color in 2016, and 72.93 million sanctioned it again in 2020. Despite our ideal of an unbroken line towards justice and racial equity in America, the overwhelming support of Trump's base reveals that the arc of the moral universe doesn't bend naturally.

Our empathy is selective and exclusionary

The statement "Black Lives Matter" itself repudiates those logics that diminish Black personhood. But Trumpism is not an anomaly, and this rhetoric did not emerge in a hermetically sealed space. Trapped in a history we are only beginning to understand, the twin pandemics of racism and the coronavirus have laid bare the chasm between America's real history and its seductive national mythology.

Despite the historic nature of the pandemic, the coronavirus is a continuation of racial disparities in sickness and death; as historian of American law and Yale Law School professor Dr. John Fabian Witt said in an interview with *The Politic*, it has served as "a lamp that has illuminated some basic features of American social life."

The distribution of sickness and death has always mirrored systems of racial inequality. Deep beneath the Atlantic Ocean's waters are the enslaved Africans thrown overboard on the ship *La Rodeur*, discarded because the spread of ophthalmia, a disease that causes temporary blindness, made them too difficult to sell. Today, Black women die from pregnancy and childbirth-related complications at two to three times the rate of white and Hispanic women, due to doctors' inability to recognize their pain and the structures of racism that deprive them of wages, affordable housing, quality education, and adequate medical care.

This country has never hesitated to abandon the people it deems essential yet expendable. Enslaved Africans built this nation: Their bodies were America's largest financial asset in the nineteenth century. Plantation owners industrialized the exploitation of Black women's reproductive labor in service of the American economy during slavery; their health was compromised for medical experimentation, too. Yet, despite this nation's

dependency on Black bodies, its healthcare system abandons and discriminates against the descendents of those same women.

The illnesses of American exceptionalism and individualism are deadlier than the coronavirus. The mythology of settler colonialism and American exceptionalism are made possible only by erasing violence against Black, brown, and Indigenous peoples. The disproportionate impact of the coronavirus on communities of color is a continuation of those oppressive dynamics. And with an ever-rising death toll, the costs of our inability to see each other's humanity and act with the health and safety of our communities in mind rises by the hour.

In an age in which videos of state-sanctioned violence against Black men are spread like the lynching postcards of the early 20th century, American society has become numb to the anguish of the people it places at the margins. This is a society where people find it easier to empathize with Kyle Rittenhouse than Jacob Blake, George Floyd, Breonna Taylor, and Ahmaud Arbery. After Rittenhouse murdered two people in the unrest after a Kenosha police officer Jacob Blake, the crowdfunding website Give Send Go fundraised nearly half a million dollars for his legal expenses.

A recent Center for Disease Control report found that most children who died of the coronavirus were of color. And in a national conversation that elides the intersectional failures that made this reality possible—choosing instead to amplify feel-good rhetoric assuring that we're all in this together—these deaths occur without acknowledgement. Black and brown children dying is the rule and not the exception. In death, as in life, the lives of people who are Black, Indigenous, incarcerated, and of color are deemed disposable.

The brutalized bodies of Black children like Emmett Till, Tamir Rice, and Trayvon Martin are evidence of this nation's failure to pass the litmus test of its Constitution—Thomas Jefferson's vision of a democratic America was not expansive enough to include Black and brown people. It still does not include them to this day. Before Black children return to dust, we adultify them, demonize them, and brutalize them. In rhetoric and in action, we show zero tolerance for childlike behavior. It is this mindset that has allowed Americans to justify coronavirus deaths of Black children as anything other than abhorrent.

And in a national conversation that elides the intersectional failures that made this reality possible—choosing instead to amplify feel-good rhetoric assuring that we're all in this together—these deaths occur without acknowledgement.

Black children are not the only subjects of apathy and dehumanization; the long tentacles of the carceral state do not leave undocumented migrant children unscathed either. Children who arrived at our southern border in search of safety, security, and shelter were met with the unimaginable cruelty of Customs and Border Protection, held in camps where overcrowded conditions and the lack of basic toiletries undermined the nation's professed commitment to human rights. Some, like 16-year-old Guatemalan Carlos Gregario Hernandez, had health conditions that Border Patrol failed to adequately address; Hernandez was diagnosed with the flu, placed into the unhygienic conditions of detention, and left to die. These inhumane conditions—which bear a striking resemblance to prisons and jails across the country—were perfect for the rapid spread of

the coronavirus. And with the inability to social distance and little access to running water, the terrible conditions of the refugee camp along the southern border brought on by the "Remain in Mexico" policy portend catastrophe.

The deaths of children of color are not an aberration, but a continuation of the norm. Normal was lethal for them. The President of the United States was not the first person—or the only one—to think of them as nobodies, as less than nobodies. President Trump may have taken out ads in The *New York Times* calling for the death penalty for the Central Park Five, but he was joined by a chorus of dehumanizing voices from the media. As the young adolescents became the targets of racist imagination made real, they walked into the courthouse in 1990 with demonstrators' cries of "you don't deserve to be alive" ringing in their ears.

When faced with the deaths of Black people, the American public reflexively dehumanizes and devalues them. To shift blame to the victims, mainstream media and law enforcement demonize Black male victims of police brutality posthumously. After Cleveland law enforcement gunned down twelve-year-old Tamir Rice as he threw snowballs and played with a toy pellet gun, the city of Cleveland announced that Rice was responsible for his own death. Many people on social media questioned his mother's parenting skills, and one article even dredged up an irrelevant drug trafficking charge from her past to implicate her.

Presented with the opportunity to create narratives humanizing the victims of police brutality, editorial staff stayed within the racial boundaries of empathy—a choice that primed our desensitization towards victims of both police brutality and the coronavirus. Rather than addressing the grief of families brought on by senseless killings, national publications like The *New York Times* and the *Los Angeles Times* spent years bringing up Eric Garner's weight and pre-existing conditions and Freddie Gray's police record. Now, rather than mourn alongside devastated minority communities, health secretary Alex Azar blamed their comorbidities for the death toll, deflecting from long histories of unequal access to healthy food and the deliberate attempt to deprive Black people in the South of healthcare. Americans are numb to Black death because it is what they have been taught.

Mainstream media excuses white violence, obfuscating it with language about defense of property and community. But when Black people raise reasonable objections about their lack of equal citizenship in a country that has profited from their labor since its genesis, it is somehow deemed unacceptable.

How did we become so anesthetized to the deaths and suffering of the people at society's margins? American society's pre-existing condition was a lack of regard and respect for each other, engendered by the social and political institutions that fail to protect the most marginalized. It was our willingness to perceive members of our communities as expendable that allowed for the normalization of nearly 250,000 coronavirus deaths.

This enduring inequality has been made strikingly clear in the coronavirus pandemic, drawing out the sinister underside of the current political order in America.

"The political party that controlled the White House has almost no Black constituency and is predominantly made up of white Americans," Witt stated. "One real possibility is that the Republican Party had little interest in dealing seriously with this epidemic because their constituency wasn't the constituency being worst affected."

The hyper-partisan rhetoric stemming from the federal government is all too familiar: Public health measures like mask-wearing and social distancing became another fault line ideological divide.

"Certainly blue states were expressly targets of the White House at a variety of occasions over the course of the last six months," Witt explained. "And a lot of those blue states are places with big cities and large African-American populations." The White House has repeatedly located blue states and Democrat-run cities as a source of decay in the nation. When protesters spoke in the language of the unheard in the aftermath of the Geroge Floyd killing, President Trump responded to a nation in crisis by citing the weak governance of Democratic governors and mayors. Just as President Richard Nixon did, he cloaked his attack on the civil rights movement of his era in the race-neutral language of law and order. Last year, he referred to Representative Elijah Cumming's district in Baltimore as a place that no human being would want to live in. It is no coincidence that the district has a majority-Black population. To him, Black and subhuman are synonymous.

While those in power attempt to erase Black deaths from history as it unfolds, marginalized groups are reclaiming the narrative, forcing us to contend with the humanity of people long dismissed and ignored.

Launched in May 2020 by a volunteer group of educators, artists, and organizers, Mourning Our Losses is a crowd-sourced memorial to honor and remember those who died behind bars during the coronavirus pandemic. This organization harnesses the power of narrative and storytelling to counter the dehumanizing portrayal of incarcerated people in the media and advocate for their release.

In an interview with *The Politic*, Eliza Kravitz '23, one of the primary organizers of Mourning Our Losses (MOL), stated, "The people inside [prisons] feel that they're completely dehumanized and treated like they're disposable, and that's not new. We ignore so much of what goes on beyond bars. Their brilliance is not acknowledged, and what has happened to

them is not acknowledged."

Kravitz and many other volunteers have worked tirelessly to strip away the racism, classism, and ableism that cloud our visions of one another. MOL draws a constellation of tragedies where the humanity of the incarcerated and the structural violence of the carceral state are in full view. They get us to see and acknowledge the loss of life behind bars and witness the deadly oppression that underwrites our profoundly imperfect union.

"We're trying to portray these people as human beings and not how the criminal justice system sees them," Kravitz continued. Even down to the language, MOL makes sure that the narratives emphasize the humanity of the deceased, showing that incarcerated people are far more than their crime of conviction and giving loved ones the space to honor them. They replace words like "inmate," "offender," and "prisoner" with the ever-important label of "human."

Kravitz noted legislators' failure to release incarcerated people at the beginning of the pandemic—a life-saving intervention that was implemented several months too late. Yet again, the nation disposed of the people it deemed undesirable.

That disposal and lack of regard for human life did not start with the pandemic. In death and life, people behind bars disappear into numbers and statistics, packed into overcrowded conditions where soap is often hard to find—perfect conditions for the rapid spread of the coronavirus. In a dual system that frequently favors the rich and guilty over the poor and innocent, injustice is served far too often. According to a report by the Lyndon B. Johnson School of Public Affairs at the University of Texas at Austin, 80 percent of people who died in Texas jails from the coronavirus were not convicted of a crime.

Even in a collective moment of mourning, their names go unsaid. But I choose to say their names.

In solidarity, we must remember Tiffany Mofield, who called out the all-too-familiar words "I can't breathe" as she succumbed to the coronavirus in a locked shower after prison officials failed to provide medical treatment. We must choose to remember her as the loving daughter, mother, and grandmother she was, even as we reckon with the inhumanity of her treatment. In solidarity, we remember Madonna Watson, who died in June of breast cancer and the coronavirus. Her friends and family remember her as a selfless mother with a big heart and a wonderful spirit. In solidarity, we remember James Scott, who died of the coronavirus in April; prison authorities left him in a cell with another incarcerated person who was known to be positive for the virus. He was a student in the Northwestern Prison Education Program and known for his kindness. Mofield, Watson, Scott, and so many others were somebody to someone. And their lives mattered.

> How did we become so anesthetized to the deaths and suffering of the people at society's margins?

Fleeting feelings of sadness after hearing about the pain and suffering of one person are not enough to lead us to act. What we need more than individual empathy is solidarity and an understanding of our linked fates. We know what we must demand: Mutual aid, free testing sites, plans to increase investment in public provisions and create a more equitable healthcare system. In a moment where individual actions have serious implications for public health, interdependence—across party, race, class, and gender—is the throughline in this chapter of history we are writing and living.

SEARCHING FOR

On Friday, October 30, *The Politic* hosted an intimate conversation with Isobel Yeung, a long-form documentary correspondent for *Vice News*. Her work on the Yemeni Civil War earned her two Emmy Awards, and her piece on Afghan women's rights earned a Gracie Award.

CAN YOU GIVE US A SENSE OF YOUR BACKGROUND IN JOURNALISM AND HOW YOU CAME TO WORK WITH *VICE*?

My journey into journalism was not very conventional. I studied Chinese in university. I didn't feel massively skilled in terms of getting a job [after graduating]. What I knew was that I had a huge thirst for travel and exploring the world. I grew up in a very small town in Southern England, so I had a real desire to go out, see things, and start experiencing things. I moved to Shanghai in 2009 and found myself working for the Chinese State media, which is a really great way to figure exactly what *not* to do in journalism.

I [later] made my way to freelance journalism. I've always had an affinity for TV because TV reaches such a big audience. *Vice* at the time was really exciting for me because they were interested in international stories, which is kind of rare. I also felt that they had a real platform and a real desire to tell these stories in a narrative that wasn't really getting across in the West, and certainly not in the U.S.

Immersive-style documentary felt truthful in a lot of ways to what it was like to be on the ground. I felt that if mainstream media gave international stories any time at all, it felt like a glossy package.

WHERE DO YOU SEE JOURNALISM GOING IN THE NEXT DECADE? THERE'S THIS IDEA THAT TRADITIONAL JOURNALISM IS DYING. DO YOU THINK THE FIELD AS A WHOLE IS GROWING OR DO YOU THINK THERE'S GOING TO BE STAGNATION?

I see both sides. It's sad that we're seeing this slow strangulation of local media, but at the same time, you're seeing so much evolution in terms of the amount of platforms that are available—a real growth in streaming platforms. We're seeing digital journalism, citizen journalism. I think there will always be a need for finding out the truth, and now more so than ever, because it's so easy to spread disinformation. Finding out what the truth is has become harder and harder.

HOW DO YOU SEE SOCIAL MEDIA PLAYING INTO [THE SPREAD OF DISINFORMATION]?

I think social media has made it so easy for me to get a hold of sources in places that would be really hard to find before the days of Twitter. [But] there's a huge spread of disinformation that we have to train ourselves on. That has muddied the waters for a lot of people.

IN 2019 YOU PRODUCED A PIECE ABOUT THE UIGHURS IN CHINA. CAN YOU WALK US THROUGH HOW YOU HAVE NAVIGATED THE HARSH RESTRICTIONS ON REPORTING ON THE TOPIC?

The story on the Muslim Uighurs takes place in Xinjiang, which is the strictest surveillance state in the world right now. Everyone's getting their faces scanned, their irises scanned—your phone is plugged into malware to make sure that you're not logging into foreign sites.

In terms of reporting on it, I kind of knew the area and I wanted to get more of a raw and intimate picture of what was going on. We went undercover as tourists and used hidden cameras. Before I went there, I knew from an intellectual level what was going on, but it's really hard to state how suffocating it could be. I've reported in a lot of conflict zones before, and I knew where the danger was coming from. But in Xinjiang, the danger is all around you.

WHY HAVEN'T WE SEEN A RESPONSE [FROM] A LOT OF MUSLIM-MAJORITY NATIONS [AGAINST] WHAT'S GOING ON IN CHINA?

It's really disappointing for a lot of Uighur individuals, and it just really speaks on China's power politically and economically. You also don't want to get on the wrong side of China. They have this "One Belt One Road [Initiative]" developing across the world, and

TRUTH IN CRISIS

A conversation with Vice's Isobel Yeung

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RAZEL SUANSING

it runs in a lot of developing countries that have Muslim-majorities. Turkey was one of the only countries that stood up for the Uighur people, but since then, talking to the foreign ministry, that isn't their policy anymore.

WHAT IS THE MOST TRITE STORY TOLD BY BIG U.S. NEWS OUTLETS IN THE MIDDLE EAST THAT IS EITHER OVERDONE OR MISCOMMUNICATED TO U.S. AUDIENCES?

Most stories are just underdone.

One thing that frustrated me in China was that when I was pitching these stories as a freelancer, people were just interested in stories that promoted China as "big, bad, scary China" or "freaky China." Quite a lot of media, myself included, find ourselves falling into those traps and taking stories that advance these narratives.

In the Middle East, obviously the fight against terror has been covered pretty widely, but I don't know if the average person is aware of a lot of the nuances—like why a person fights for a terrorist group or the underlying social factors that contribute to young people in al-Qaeda and ISIS. The only way to get people to care about these [events is] through stories and through building sympathy for people around the world.

People's stories are what we relate to and care about.

WHAT GOES THROUGH YOUR MIND WHEN THERE IS DENIAL FROM THESE PEOPLE IN POWER AND YOU'RE TRYING TO OBTAIN THE TRUTH?

It's twofold. Firstly, I prepare for everything pretty well and I feel like I need to read everything that's been documented everywhere for the people I have to interview. Then, in some ways I try to forget all of that and relate to that person, because I think it's important to find humanity and a common ground and to allow them to have the platform and say their peace.

At the same time, [I also keep in mind], 'What has this person actually done or said in the past that needs to be held accountable? What is the impact [of their actions] on individuals that I've met?'

Ultimately, I'm just a voice for them.

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